

Responses to the Massachusetts Voter Table Questionnaire for US Senate Candidates - Edward Markey

The Massachusetts Voter Table is a coalition of nonpartisan nonprofit organizations dedicated to increasing civic engagement in our commonwealth.

1. How do you plan to expand and protect voting rights, immediately in response to COVID-19 and permanently after the public health emergency?

I am a cosponsor of the Natural Disaster and Emergency Ballot Act (NDEBA), which would ensure Americans are still able to vote by expanding early in-person voting and no-excuse absentee vote-by-mail to all states, and allowing voters who did not receive an absentee ballot, to use a printable ballot currently only provided for military and overseas voters.

Natural disasters and public health emergencies are occurring more frequently and with greater impact than ever before, affecting the ability of victims and first responders to vote on Election Day. The lack of voting options in many states and sufficient emergency ballot procedures can leave voters disenfranchised. COVID-19, hurricanes Harvey and Irma, and the wildfires in the Western United States are recent examples of the damage and disruption that public health emergencies and natural disasters can cause. We have already seen limited incidences of poll workers not showing up on Election Day this year, due to fears of the coronavirus. The recent tornadoes in Tennessee on Super Tuesday also greatly impacted voting in the state. With fears of catching the coronavirus, the priority must be to reduce the number of people voting in person at any given time, by allowing for early voting, and for all people to be able to vote from their homes using vote-by-mail. As a last resort, voters who did not receive their absentee ballots will also need access to a printable mail in ballot that has so far only been made available to military and overseas voters.

Emergencies in the proximity of an election day can have a lasting impact as polling places deal with flooding, lack of power, or other unsafe conditions. The Natural Disaster and Emergency Ballot Act (NDEBA) represents a commonsense solution to ensuring the 2020 elections, and future elections, are resilient to emergencies and that we are protecting the voting rights of those in harm's way as well as emergency responders.

2. What is your position on reparations for Black and Indigenous people in Massachusetts and in the United States?

I am a cosponsor of Senator Booker's Commission to Study and Develop Reparation Proposals for African-Americans Act, which establishes a commission to develop reparations proposals. It is impossible to craft an American future that is fair and just without openly acknowledging and confronting the ongoing inequalities caused by slavery and a history of systemic racism in the United States. Providing reparations is an important first step to repair the generational harm inflicted on Black Americans. But this legislation is just the start of a long-overdue national conversation on the racial inequities in this country. We need bold, transformational change and a commitment to eradicating the systemic racism present in education, housing, health, employment, and all other sectors of our society. We need all-encompassing justice for communities of color.

3. How does race impact the distribution of environmental benefits and burdens in Massachusetts?

Black, Latinx, Indigenous, and other communities of color are exposed to the highest levels of air pollution and toxic chemicals, and suffer some of the worst climate impacts. This disproportionate burden is caused by a long history of systemic racism in housing, employment, the economy, and the political system. We see this firsthand in Chelsea, which is a major transit hub and is home to the storage site for all the jet fuel for Logan Airport and several industrial sites—exposing residents to air pollution and toxic chemicals. We see this in East Boston, which is why I have been fighting against the construction of a dangerous electrical substation directly next to the jet fuel storage site. And we see this in Lawrence, which was devastated by natural

gas explosions in 2018. I worked to hold Columbia Gas accountable for its failures and introduced the Leonel Rondon Pipeline Safety Act with Senator Elizabeth Warren and Rep. Lori Trahan to make sure no other community has to endure that kind of catastrophe, but there is no doubt that communities of color are more at risk of experiencing these kinds of disasters.

All of these examples are why I co-authored the Green New Deal resolution with Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, which centers the needs and experiences of frontline, under- resourced, and vulnerable communities. As part of the Green New Deal, we will work to right historic wrongs, while also ensuring that the economic and health benefits of climate action and the clean energy economy are felt in communities that have been shut out in the past. All people and all communities have a right to breathe clean air, drink clean water, access healthy food, and participate in a clean economy—we need a Green New Deal in order to bring that promise to life for communities of color.

4. What is your plan for providing permanent protection 11 million undocumented residents in the US?

We cannot and should not rely on the courts to provide legal protection and dignity for our nation's immigrants. That is why I have worked in Congress to support the vibrant immigrant and refugee community in Massachusetts and around the country. I support the Dream and Promise Act, which would provide a path to citizenship for TPS recipients and many Dreamers. But the Dream and Promise Act is just the start of what Congress must do.

We have an obligation to provide safety, security, dignity, respect, and opportunity to the 11 million undocumented immigrants who enrich our nation. Citizenship for only some cannot be our end goal. We must work to provide a pathway to citizenship for the entirety of the undocumented population living in the United States. Unless we make a stand now, the Trump administration's anti-immigrant agenda will leave a stain on this nation and forever upend the very foundations of democracy in the United States.

5. At least 16,000 Southeast Asian community members who entered the US as refugees have final orders for deportation, many of which are based on old criminal convictions. What is your plan to address the prison-to-deportation pipeline?

The Trump administration has repeatedly shown its unconscionable willingness to prioritize hardline immigration enforcement measures over the well-being of immigrant families. We need to end our prison-to-deportation pipeline that rips families and communities apart. We should not punish people under our immigration laws for minor and decades-old criminal convictions. We must overhaul our immigration laws to reflect our values of rehabilitation and to acknowledge that especially in the case of refugees, past trauma may have led to or complicated previous behaviors. We need to enact immigration laws and enforcement priorities that are not punitive to those trying to live better, law-abiding lives. I will fight to put a stop to the criminalization of immigrants and the increasingly inhumane treatment they face in the United States.

6. What are your proposals to address the crisis of rental housing affordable to low-income people, including people experiencing homelessness?

In Massachusetts, we have a deficit of 169,809 rental homes that are affordable and available for extremely low-income renters. A family needs to make nearly \$60,000 a year to be able to afford a two-bedroom apartment at fair market rent here in the Bay State. This is unsustainable, and we need a comprehensive approach to the crisis facing

our nation and acutely in Massachusetts.

I fully support much greater investments in our public housing system, and I stood with Representatives Stephen Lynch and Hakeem Jeffries in South Boston where we called for a \$70 billion infusion in our public housing system over the next five years. And it is why I believe it is so important to protect and expand the existing rental assistance programs of the federal government, like Housing Choice Vouchers and Project-Based Rental Assistance programs.

The federal government has not done enough to address this issue and has left the problem for states and localities to deal with on their own. That needs to change, and is why I am a co-sponsor of Senator Elizabeth Warren's plan to invest \$500 billion in affordable housing. That plan --the American Housing and Economic Mobility Act -- would leverage federal investments to build up to 3.2 million new housing units for lower-income and middle-class families, reduce rental costs by ten percent over the next ten years, and incentivize localities to put increase their housing supply, all while creating 1.5 million new jobs.

7. 69% of white families in Massachusetts own their home compared with only 32% of households of color. What specific proposals do you have to close the racial homeownership gap?

There are two things we should do right now to close this gap. First and foremost, we must absolutely put a stop to the Trump administration's current attempt to dismantle the Community Reinvestment Act (CRA). The CRA is an important law that protects communities from illegal redlining and focus lending efforts on meeting needs of communities of color. But the Office of the Comptroller of the Currency recently released a change to this law that will allow banks to skirt the requirements of ensuring lending to underserved communities. This is an immediate threat to low- and moderate- income communities across the country, and we must fight every step of the way to make sure these bad changes never go into effect.

Second, we need to recognize that a disproportionate lack of health care, educational, and economic opportunities, as well as scant federal investment in communities of color, have kept homeownership unfairly out of reach for many of these households. That is why the Green New Deal calls for repairing the historic oppression underserved communities. Specifically: "providing all people of the United States with— high-quality health care; affordable, safe, and adequate housing; economic security; and clean water, clean air, healthy and affordable food, and access to nature. That also is why I have called for cutting the defense budget by ten percent, including calling for the slashing of the nuclear weapons budget by \$875 billion, and specifically using these

funds to invest jobs, education, health care and housing in American communities where the poverty rate is at least 25 percent.